Ben-Chi Ma | Curriculum Vitae

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Department of Aerospace and Mechanical Engineering

EDUCATION

University of Notre Dame — **Notre Dame, IN, USA**
Ph.D. in Mechanical Engineering — *Aug. 2024–Present*
Department of Aerospace and Mechanical Engineering, Advisor: Prof. Tengfei Luo
Research focus: AI-accelerated multiscale materials modeling and phonon thermal transport in semiconductors and at interfaces

Xi'an Jiaotong University — **Xi'an, Shaanxi, China**
M.Phil, GPA: 3.64/4.0 (Rank 2/105) — *Sept. 2021–Jun. 2024*
Major in Power Engineering and Engineering Thermophysics, School of Energy and Power Engineering
Thesis topic: Optical regulation of nanomaterials for spectral splitting and passive radiative sub-ambient cooling application in solar cell
• ***Awards: National Scholarship, Excellent Postgraduate Student Cadre, Qiyiyi Research Institution Scholarship, Outstanding Volunteer in 11th National Paralympic Games and the 8th Special Olympics (Xi'an, Shaanxi)***

Xi'an Jiaotong University — **Xi'an, Shaanxi, China**
B.Eng in Mechanical Engineering, GPA: 3.80/4.0 (Rank 1/31) — *Sept. 2017–Jul. 2021*
Major in New Energy Science and Engineering, School of Energy and Power Engineering
• ***Awards: The First Prize Scholarship, The Second Prize Scholarship, YINGDE Gases Scholarship, Chen Xuejun Undergraduate Scholarship, Excellent Student, Excellent Student Cadre, Outstanding League Cadres, First Prizes of Shaanxi province of 2018 and 2019 China Undergraduate Mathematical Contest in Modelling (CUMCM), Meritorious Winner in Mathematical Contest in Modeling (MCM), No.1 in National 100 Excellent Graduation Theses (Design) Competition in Energy and Power.***
• Attended the 2019 Hong Kong Polytechnic University Summer International School and studied two courses gaining A and A- grades respectively.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Doctoral Research at University of Notre Dame

Graduate Research Assistant — **Notre Dame, IN, USA**
Advisor: Prof. Tengfei Luo — *Aug. 2024–Present*

- **Phonon spectra and interfacial thermal transport at GaN/Al_2O_3 dislocation cores.** Ran molecular dynamics with a foundation machine-learning interatomic potential (MACE) on ∼1200-atom interface models. Resolved region-specific phonon density of states and EELS-like spectra at dislocation core and bridge sites, and evaluated elastic interfacial thermal conductance with the atomistic Green's function method (manuscript in preparation).
- **Machine-learning potentials for thermal conductivity of InGaAs.** Benchmarking self-trained Deep Potential models against foundation MLIPs (MACE, DPA) for phonon dispersion and lattice thermal conductivity of $In_{1-x}Ga_xAs$, using phono3py and the virtual-crystal approximation; building a reproducible MLIP-to-phonon workflow.
- **Multiscale thermal modeling of GaN power and RF transistors** (sponsored by Lockheed Martin). Coupled GPU-accelerated multi-band phonon Boltzmann transport simulations with Fourier conduction to resolve non-Fourier near-junction heating, and quantified junction-to-backside thermal resistance of GaN-on-Si power FETs versus substrate thinning and carrier choice. Contributed to physics-informed neural network solvers for the phonon BTE.
- **Phonon band discretization for the deterministic BTE solver JAX-BTE.** Developed frequency–mean-free-path band binning with κ-conserving band aggregation, replacing the original row-order binning, and a solver-free rule for splitting a band budget between frequency windows and MFP sub-bins. Benchmarked bulk, thin-film, interface and TDTR cases against a reference solver; the new binning reduces discretization error at equal band count (manuscript in preparation).

Course Project — **Notre Dame, IN, USA**
CSE 60772 High Performance Distributed Systems — *Fall 2026*

- Accelerating a *P. falciparum* whole-genome variant-calling pipeline (BWA-MEM, Picard, GATK) for bulk segregant analysis on the CRC cluster, through chromosome-level scatter-gather on a single node and distributed execution with TaskVine, with variant calls kept identical to the baseline.

Teaching at University of Notre Dame

Teaching Assistant — **Notre Dame, IN, USA**
AME 21268 Design Tools II (undergraduate) — *Fall 2024–Present*

- In-class teaching assistant; grade homework and final assessments.
- Guide students in SolidWorks 3D CAD modeling, CAM simulation, engineering mechanics and structural analysis, Ackermann steering geometry, and engineering design projects.

Guest Instructional Session **Notre Dame, IN, USA**

Academic English Writing (non-credit course) *Fall 2024*

- Introduced Zotero for academic writing: literature organization, citation and bibliography management, and writing workflows.

Research in State Key Laboratory of Multiphase Flow in Power Engineering

Lab Member **Xi'an, China**

MFREC Group, supervisor: Prof. Dengwei Jing (dwjing@mail.xjtu.edu.cn) *Sept. 2021–Jun. 2024*

- Focused on the optical regulation of nanomaterials for spectral splitting, solar energy conversion in CPV/T system and passive radiative sub-ambient cooling coatings application in solar cell. Co-authored **11** SCI papers (including **2** as first author), **1** invention patent and **1** software copyright.
- Made contributions to 5 national programs and foundations in our Lab.
- Had experiences in setup of CPVT-Hydrogen system, preparation and characterization of nanomaterials and polymer-dielectric composite materials, and testing of thermal and optical properties, numerical simulation through COMSOL Multiphysics.

Teaching Assistant **Xi'an, China**

Undergraduate Course: Hydrogen and New Energy Power Systems *Sept. 2021- Dec. 2022*

- Taught laboratory courses for **82** students up to **8** hours, evaluating and totaling student grades.

Key R&D projects with corporate cooperation

Group member **Xi'an, China & Tacheng, China**

Solar Photo/ Thermal/ Electric Coupling Hydrogen Production Project *Sept. 2021- Sept. 2022*

- Cooperated with State Power Investment Group Xinjiang Energy Chemical Co., Ltd. to complete the industrialization demonstration project of solar photo/thermal/electric coupling hydrogen production technology.
- Worked together with the team to iterate and upgrade the system, and have built 50 system setups in Tacheng, Xinjiang.

Undergraduate Research Project Design in Xi'an Jiaotong University

Group Leader **Xi'an, China & Tacheng, China**

Fully self-sustaining solar absorption based water harvesting unit *Jan. 2020- Sept. 2021*

- Led a group of **5** undergraduates and finished the project. We received an A+ grade in in program evaluation, published **2** related review articles and won **5** science and innovation competitions. I optimized the design of the heat transfer structure by numerical simulation, built the device and tested the performance in the team.

PUBLICATIONS

Journal Articles

[1] Jiahang Zhou, Ruiyang Li, Wenjie Shang, Yi Liu, J.P. Panda, Pan Du, Xin-Yang Liu, Jasmine Liang, **Ben-Chi Ma**, Jian-Xun Wang, and Tengfei Luo. Physics-informed neural networks with hard-encoded angle-dependent boundary conditions for phonon Boltzmann transport equation. *Materials Today Physics*, 59:101922, 2025. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.mtphys.2025.101922

[2] Qingxi Xin, **Benchi Ma**, Jiaying Ru, Yu Zhou, and Dengwei Jing. Efficient passive cooling over a novel bifunctional polymer bilayer composite simultaneously possessing radiative and evaporative cooling properties. *Advanced Energy Materials*, 15(14):2404122, 2025. https://doi.org/10.1002/aenm.202404122

[3] Jiwei Li, **Benchi Ma**, Hongxia Wang, Yizhou Zhu, Yujie Gu, and Dengwei Jing. A novel photovoltaic-thermal system based on spectral splitting of nanoparticle suspensions for simultaneous hydrogen production and seawater desalination. *Energy Conversion and Management*, 314:118670, 2024. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enconman.2024.118670

[4] **Ben-Chi Ma**, Maochang Liu, Yizhou Zhu, Kefan Chen, Lixia Pan, Chaoqian Ai, and Dengwei Jing. Record passive radiative cooling of over 15 ℃ by a micro-nanoporous granular composite film. *ACS Applied Energy Materials*, 7(12):5064–5070, 2024. https://doi.org/10.1021/acsaem.4c00675

[5] Xinlong Lu, Devendra Yadav, **Benchi Ma**, Lijing Ma, and Dengwei Jing. Rapid detachment of hydrogen bubbles for electrolytic water splitting driven by combined effects of Marangoni force and the electrostatic repulsion. *Journal of Power Sources*, 599:234217, 2024. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpowsour.2024.234217

[6] Devendra Yadav, Xinlong Lu, **Ben-Chi Ma**, and Dengwei Jing. Advancements in microreactor technology for hydrogen production via steam reforming: A comprehensive review of numerical studies. *Journal of Power Sources*, 596:234090, 2024. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jpowsour.2024.234090

[7] Yizhou Zhu, **Benchi Ma**, Baichuan He, Xinyu Ma, and Dengwei Jing. Liquid spherical lens as an effective auxiliary optical unit for CPV/T system with remarkable hydrogen production efficiency. *Applied Energy*, 334:120733, 2023. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.apenergy.2023.120733

[8] **Ben-Chi Ma**, Hua Lin, Yizhou Zhu, Zilong Zeng, Jiafeng Geng, and Dengwei Jing. A new Concentrated Photovoltaic Thermal-Hydrogen system with photocatalyst suspension as optical liquid filter. *Renewable Energy*, 194:1221–1232, 2022. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.renene.2022.06.013

[9] Yizhou Zhu, **Benchi Ma**, Zilong Zeng, Hewei Lou, Yi He, and Dengwei Jing. Solar collector tube as secondary concentrator for significantly enhanced optical performance of LCPV/T system. *Renewable Energy*, 193:418–433, 2022. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.

renene.2022.04.165

[10] Zhihui Chen, Jinwen Shi, Yueqi Li, **Benchi Ma**, Xueli Yan, Maochang Liu, Hui Jin, Dong Li, Dengwei Jing, and Liejin Guo. Recent progress of energy harvesting and conversion coupled with atmospheric water gathering. *Energy Conversion and Management*, 246:114668, 2021. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.enconman.2021.114668

[11] Zhihui Chen†, Shiyu Song†, **Benchi Ma**†, Yueqi Li, Yu Shao, Jinwen Shi, Maochang Liu, Hui Jin, and Dengwei Jing. Recent progress on sorption/desorption-based atmospheric water harvesting powered by solar energy. *Solar Energy Materials and Solar Cells*, 230:111233, 2021. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.solmat.2021.111233

[12] Zilong Zeng, Lijun Sun, Heng Liu, **Benchi Ma**, Dengwei Jing, and Liejin Guo. Should the tubular photocatalytic reactors work continuously or in an intermittent manner instead? *Industrial & Engineering Chemistry Research*, 60(12):4610–4621, 2021. https://doi.org/10.1021/acs.iecr.1c00463

† Equal contribution. Full record: ORCID 0000-0002-1556-5974

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

SciML Workshop at the University of Notre Dame (SciML@ND 2026) — **Notre Dame, IN, USA**
Poster: Machine-learning-assisted multiscale phonon transport in AlGaN/GaN HEMTs — *Sept. 2026*

42nd International Conference on Thermoelectrics (ICT 2026) — **Houston, TX, USA**
Oral: Concurrent-learning deep potential for thermal transport in $In_{1-x}Ga_xAs$ alloys (B.-C. Ma, Z. Xu, T. Luo) — *May 2026*

ASME 2025 Summer Heat Transfer Conference (SHTC 2025) — **Westminster, CO, USA**
Technical presentation (SHTC2025-164577) — *Jul. 2025*
Multiscale thermal transport modeling for GaN transistors: Bridging first-principles and the phonon Boltzmann equation

Annual Conference on Multiphase Flow of Chinese Society of Engineering Thermophysics — **Suzhou, China**
Study on the compatibility of spectral selective regulation between Pt@TiO_2 photothermal — *Dec. 2021*

Annual Conference on Multiphase Flow of Chinese Society of Engineering Thermophysics — **Shanghai, China**
Spectrally Modulated Thermoplastic Polyurethane Films with Gas-Solid Micro/Nanostructures for Radiative Cooling — *Oct. 2023*

INTERNSHIPS

Suzhou Transportation Investment Group Co., Ltd. — **Suzhou, China**
Intern — *Jul. 2020- Aug. 2020*

- Completed a research report on the state-of-art of development of the hydrogen industry, which was appreciated by the Chairman of the branch, as well as won the honors of Outstanding Research Report and Outstanding Internship in the competition.

SKILLS

Computational

Materials modeling: Machine-learning interatomic potentials (MACE, DPA, DeePMD), molecular dynamics (ASE), lattice dynamics and phonon transport (phono3py, ALAMODE), deterministic phonon BTE (JAX-BTE), atomistic Green's function, finite-volume and multiscale BTE–Fourier thermal modeling

Programming: Python (JAX, NumPy/SciPy), Git/GitHub, Bash, LaTeX; experience with C++, Fortran and MATLAB

HPC: GPU computing, UGE and HTCondor clusters (Notre Dame CRC), parallel and distributed workflows (TaskVine), reproducible pipelines with NAS backup

AI-assisted research: Vibe coding and agentic development with AI coding agents (Claude Code, Codex); designed a multi-agent research workflow with a Git-versioned shared project memory and review-before-merge governance across multiple machines and clusters

Engineering: COMSOL Multiphysics, SolidWorks, Inventor, CAD, Matlab/Simulink, NI LabVIEW

Experiment

- Skilled in material preparation, system design, and characterization like GC, Spectrophotometry, SEM, XRD, FT-IR, etc.

Languages

Chinese: Native Language

English: TOEFL iBT — *Scores:91*